converge for the Shansabanis' long-awaited triumph over the erstwhile Yamini capital. In what could be termed a historical irony, it was the Oghüz who provided a pivotal catalyst for this victory: they had not only occupied Ghazna by *c.* AH 556/1161–1162 CE, their further encampments and disruptive movements ranged beyond Zabulistan into Zamindawar (map, p. xvi).[5] Thence, these disruptions touched Shihab al-Din's new territories of Tiginabad and its vicinity. His repeated confrontations with the Oghüz in turn brought him in contact with the once great capital: as the apparent core of the Oghüz's regional presence, the city necessarily had to have their encampments eradicated for a final solution to the "Oghüz problem."[6] In AH 568–569/1173 CE, the definitive routing of the Oghüz from Ghazna – the "Port of India" – established a third Shansabani lineage with the crowning of Shihab al-Din as Sultan Mu'izz al-Din.[7]

Past scholarship has tended to absorb the Ghazna Shansabanis into an overarching "Ghurid" dispensation. But considering them as a deputation acting on the orders of (or otherwise subordinate to) the Firuzkuh Shansabanis leads to a historical misperception: based on this assumption, the renown of the successful India campaigns usually accrues to the Firuzkuh branch as the senior lineage.[8] In Chapters 1 and 3, we already took note of the multiple geo-cultural, socio-economic, and indeed unforeseen historical factors – along with the possibility of intimate emotional interventions – that collectively presented alternatives to the textual interpretations (such as Juzjani's) of Shansabani expansion as a process centrally orchestrated from Firuzkuh. In addition, throughout the preceding chapters we have also seen the powerful *physical* indices of centrifugal tendencies among the Shansabani lineages, as they crafted imperial infrastructures in keeping with the differing cultural geographies they each inhabited.

Although a small market town in the mid-first millennium CE, Ghazna had grown to a sizeable commercial center by the tenth century. The settlement was the principal waystation on the Kabul–Qandahar route, with access to the Kurraman and Gomal passes (cf. Chapter 1) and the middle Indus's alluvia (map, p. xv). Moreover, with the Rutbils' dominance of Zabulistan and the contiguous region of Zamindawar possibly as late as the tenth century, Ghazna also became a major Buddhist monastic center. As was the case with Bamiyan, the site's command of an important node within a political geography combined with its Buddhist aspects, making it a busy commercial and pilgrimage center "securing the Central Asian and Iranian relations with India."[9]

It would not be unreasonable to propose, then, that the Shansabanis of Ghazna underwent a further differentiation as an increasingly independent lineage, akin to the Shansabanis of Bamiyan. Similar to their agnates, the Ghazna Shansabanis inhabited a distinct historical–cultural geography within Afghanistan: rather than the links of Firuzkuh with